COMP1913 - International Data Analytics 2026-2027 (Term 3)

Assessment 2 – Individual Report – Instructions

Assessment Overview

In today's data-driven business environment, senior decision-makers frequently rely on consultancy reports to guide strategic choices. These reports often present complex data through visualisations and analytical summaries which, if poorly designed or biased, can lead to misleading conclusions. The ability to critically investigate such reports is therefore a vital skill for business and management professionals.

This assessment requires students to conduct a desk-based case study investigation of a real-world consultancy publication: **Bain & Company's *Innovation Report 2025***. Students will examine the **business problem addressed by the report** and critically evaluate how quantitative evidence and data visualisations are used to support innovation-related decision-making. Particular emphasis is placed on assessing the effectiveness of visualisations, recognising potential cognitive bias, and evaluating the suitability of analytical tools used to support managerial judgement.

Key Details

- This assessment accounts for 50% weighting of your final grade in this module.
- You need at least 50% passing marks to pass this assessment.
- The report should be 2,000 words, excluding references.

What is Required in this Assessment:

You must submit a report that investigates and critically evaluates the case study by addressing the following areas:

1. Business problem and case framing: Identify and explain the business problem or decision context addressed in Bain & Company's *Innovation Report 2025*. Discuss the purpose of the report, its intended audience, and its relevance to managerial decision-making.

2. Evaluation of quantitative evidence and visualisations: Critically evaluate the data visualisations presented in the report. Assess their clarity, accuracy, and

appropriateness and evaluate how effectively they support the business argument. Where relevant, consider whether alternative visualisation methods could improve decision support.

3. Evaluation of analytical tools and decision support: Critically comment on the types of analytical or visualisation tools that may have been used to produce the report's figures (e.g. business intelligence or analytics software). Assess the suitability of these tools for supporting data-driven decision-making and recommend improvements where appropriate.
4. Data integrity and cognitive bias: Examine whether the data or its presentation may lead to misinterpretation, oversimplification, or biased conclusions. Identify potential cognitive biases (such as framing or confirmation bias) that could influence decision-makers' understanding of the findings.

5. Recommendations: Provide clear, evidence-based recommendations for decision-makers regarding how the findings should be interpreted and how the use of data, analytics, or visualisations could be improved.

The Structure of your Report

1. Executive Summary: Overview of the case study, key findings and recommendations.
2. Background: Introduction to Bain & Company's *Innovation Report 2025*, including the business problem and decision-making context.
3. Evaluation: Evidence-based critique of:
    a) the potential cognitive biases that might influence a reader's decision-making
    b) the visuals presented in their report (what are their strengths and weaknesses, are there any information gaps or potential for misinterpretation).
4. Recommendations: Clear points to improve a decision maker's approach to the subject given your evaluation and findings.
5. References: Appropriate academic and practitioner sources.

Assessment Criteria:

Criteria	Description	Marks
Depth of critical evaluation	Evaluate the content rigorously, identifying strengths, weaknesses, information gaps, and potential biases. Demonstrate an understanding of how these aspects influence decision-making and data interpretation.	30%
Quality and clarity of visualisations	Assess the effectiveness, clarity, and appropriateness of the visualisations. Evaluate their ability to accurately represent the underlying data and convey the intended message. Consider alternative visualisation methods where applicable.	40%
Structure, coherence, and presentation of the report	Present the report in a logical, well-organised structure with clear sections. Ensure coherence in arguments, professional presentation, and adherence to formatting and stylistic guidelines.	20%
Focus	Ensure the report remains focused on evaluating the visualisations and potential biases within the context of the research question. Address key aspects such as clarity, data integrity and relevance to the research objectives and audience. Provides a clear recommendation at the end.	10%

Assessment Rationale

This assessment develops students' ability to investigate a real-world business case and critically evaluate how quantitative evidence, analytical tools and data visualisations are used to support managerial decision-making. By framing Bain & Company's *Innovation Report 2025* as a desk-based case study, students address Learning Outcomes 3, 4, and 5 through critical analysis, evaluation of decision-support tools, and professional report writing, strengthening analytical judgement, ethical awareness, and employability-focused consultancy skills.